

100 Days of Azure DevOps

Day 19 Handout — Branch policies are parental controls for adults who still push to main at 11:58pm

2 - Azure Repos & Git Mastery · Personal lab only · Educational content · Not a sales pitch

Architecture A — policy stack on refs/heads/main

Policy	Azure Repos setting	Lab value
Minimum reviewers	Require a minimum number of reviewers	1 (yourself OK)
Linked work items	Check for linked work items	Required
Merge types	Limit merge types	Allow squash only
Comment resolution	Check for comment resolution	Optional today; on in real teams
Build validation	Build pipeline must succeed	Add after Day 21 YAML exists
Status checks	External GitHub/ADO statuses	Skip unless you add one
Reset on push / stale reviews	Require approval on last iteration	On if you want serious review

Architecture B — decide required vs optional (constraint, not vibes)

Constraint	Required?	Skip when
Stop git push origin main	Yes — require PR + deny Contribute on main or policy	Never on this lab after today
Traceability for DORA / audit	Linked work item Required	Throwaway branches not merging to main
Linear history	Squash only	You truly need merge commits for two parents
CI as a gate	Build validation on azure-pipelines.yml	YAML does not exist yet (Day 21)
Two-person integrity	2 reviewers	Solo personal lab — 1 is enough
Admin bypass	Keep PCA bypass for breakglass	Do not use bypass for daily commits

Architecture C — pitfalls that queue PRs or still allow a 11:58pm push

Pitfall	What you see	Fix
Policy on develop, not main	main still accepts git push	Branch policies on the default branch
Reviewers = 1 but you auto-approve without looking	Green checkbox, unread diff	Use Files tab; optional: prohibit requestor vote
All merge types allowed	Merge commit + rebase mix on main	Limit to squash as per ADR
Work item optional	PRs with no AB#	Set Check for linked work items = Required
Bypass policies permission	Direct push succeeds for Contributors	Day 17 Deny; re-check Effective rights
Build validation pointing at Classic	Wrong pipeline, always skipped	Wait for YAML; then pick the right definition

One-liner to remember

Branch policies are parental controls for adults who still push to main at 11:58pm.

Step-by-step lab (personal Azure / Azure DevOps only)

Personal azure-100-labs. Harden main. Then prove a direct push fails. No work project policies.

- 1 Repos → Branches → ... on main → Branch policies.
- 2 Require a minimum number of reviewers: 1. Allow requestors to approve their own changes (solo lab).
- 3 Check for linked work items: Required.
- 4 Limit merge types: uncheck Merge / Rebase / Semi-linear; leave Squash merge checked.
- 5 Save. Locally: git switch main && echo bypass > notes/should-fail.txt && git add && git commit -m "docs: should be blocked" && git push origin main
- 6 Expect rejected by policy. Delete the local commit: git reset --hard origin/main (only if push failed and commit is local).
- 7 Open a PR from a feature branch with a linked work item and squash-complete it to prove the happy path.

Prove direct push to main is rejected (then reset local)

```
git switch main
git pull origin main
echo blocked > notes/should-fail.txt
git add notes/should-fail.txt
git commit -m "docs: should be blocked by branch policy"
git push origin main
# TF401027 / TF402455 / 'rejected by policy' – success for this lab
git reset --hard origin/main
```

Done checklist

- main requires 1 reviewer and a linked work item
- Merge types limited to squash
- Direct git push origin main failed
- A compliant PR still merges

Tomorrow — Day 20

Phase 2 mini project